Change Management Policy

Effective Date:
March 05, 2026

Category:
Systems Management

Scheduled Review:
March 2027

1. Authority

Executive Order 2016-06, Enterprise Information Technology Governance

2. Document Control

This document replaces, in its entirety, the *Change Management Policy*, dated January 6, 2025.

3. Purpose

This Information Technology Policy (ITP) establishes and maintains the policy, responsibilities, and procedures for Change Management maintenance, specifically the creation of change Blackout periods and Maintenance Windows, on the Commonwealth's enterprise information technology platforms.

4. Scope

This policy applies to all offices, departments, boards, commissions, and councils under the Governor's jurisdiction and any other entity connecting to the Commonwealth Network (hereinafter referred to as "agencies").

5. Policy

For definitions found within this document, refer to the *IT Policy Glossary*.

The Office of Administration, Office for Information Technology (OA/IT) established the following maintenance procedures to ensure that Enterprise Services are available during the most critical and heavily used time periods:

- **Maintenance Windows** (predetermined dates and times for scheduled maintenance)
- **Blackout Windows** (designated periods during which non-emergency changes are restricted or prohibited)

All changes shall be documented and approved in the Enterprise IT Service Management

(ITSM) tool prior to implementation. OA/IT staff shall frequently check the enterprise ITSM tool to carefully review, ask questions, assess the risk of change, work to minimize system down time, and if appropriate approve enterprise changes. OA/IT staff should assign a delegate in the enterprise ITSM tool to review change tickets if they are absent from work or otherwise unavailable to conduct the reviews.

Approved Enterprise Changes (those Enterprise Change Requests which have been approved in the Enterprise ITSM tool) shall be implemented on a weekly basis during a scheduled "Enterprise Maintenance Window". The dates and times for implementation of enterprise maintenance are detailed in *Enterprise Maintenance Windows Standard.*

5.1 Maintenance Outside Approved Windows

Enterprise Maintenance that cannot be scheduled during one of the routine scheduled Maintenance Windows requires approval from the Enterprise Change Advisory Board (CAB) or designated Enterprise Management.

Emergency changes or maintenance are exempt from Maintenance Windows or Blackout restrictions; however, they require approval from Enterprise Emergency CAB and the technical area where the emergency is taking place.

All high-risk changes shall generate a notification to the Chief Information Security Officer (CISO) or delegate.

All changes involving security Configuration Item (CI) shall require CISO or delegate approval.

Scanning activities are not considered maintenance and not subject to Maintenance Windows or Blackouts.

5.2 Limited, Shared Infrastructure and Comprehensive Production Blackout Window Requests

5.2.1 Limited

A limited Blackout only affects a single Delivery Center, and the Blackout is limited to the Delivery Center requesting it. To request a limited Blackout, agencies shall complete the *Change Blackout Request Form* and e-mail the form to ra-oaetsocab@pa.gov.

Changes submitted during a limited Blackout will require the Blackout agency approval only if a Configuration Item (CI) referenced on the change request is related to the agency that has the Blackout maintenance. Agency or Delivery Center Change Managers in coordination with the Enterprise Change Manager will determine if the change requests can be accommodated.

Scenario 1: If Pennsylvania State Police (PSP) has a limited Blackout and the Department of Corrections (DOC) is creating a change request within the PSP blackout window, and the affected CIs do not relate to PSP, no PSP Blackout approval is required.

Scenario 2: If PSP has a limited Blackout and the DOC is creating a change

request within the PSP Blackout window, and the affected CIs relate to PSP, a PSP Blackout approval is required.

5.2.2 Shared Infrastructure

OA/IT manages Shared Infrastructure. The Blackout processes for Shared Infrastructure work as detailed in the following scenarios:

Scenario 3: If OA/IT has a limited Blackout (not comprehensive) and PSP is creating a change request within the OA/IT Blackout window, and the affected CIs do not relate to OA/IT managed CIs, no OA/IT Blackout approval is needed.

Scenario 4: If OA/IT has a limited Blackout (not comprehensive) and PSP is creating a change request within the OA/IT Blackout window, and the affected CIs relate to OA/IT managed CI's, an OA/IT Blackout approval is required.

Scenario 5: If DOC has a Blackout, and PSP is creating a change request within DOC Blackout window, and the affected CIs are on Shared Infrastructure at OA/IT on which DOC is operating, a DOC Blackout approval is required.

5.2.3 Comprehensive

No maintenance can be performed by any agency during a comprehensive Blackout period. Usually, these occur during critical events within the Commonwealth (elections, official state visits, etc.).

If a comprehensive Blackout is required, the requesting agency shall provide the Enterprise Change Manager with a thirty (30) business-day notice prior to the Blackout window.

The agency shall complete the *Change Blackout Request Form* and send it to ra-oaetsocab@pa.gov. Agency or Delivery Center Change Managers and Enterprise Change Manager will determine if a change can be accommodated and respond to the agency.

When it is determined that a comprehensive Blackout for all maintenance is needed, approvals must be obtained from the Commonwealth Chief Technology Officer (CTO). The Enterprise Change Managers will post this Blackout in the Enterprise ITSM tool once approval is received.

If a comprehensive Blackout is approved, change submitters will be unable to submit any non-emergency changes in the Enterprise ITSM tool.

5.3 Override Authority

The Commonwealth's Chief Information Officer (CIO), CTO, or CISO have the authority to override a Blackout rejection via the Enterprise CAB process. In addition, the Commonwealth's CIO, CTO, or CISO has the authority to delay and/or block any change to mitigate risks associated with changes.

6. Contact

Questions or comments may be directed via email to OA, IT Policy.

7. Exception from Policy

In the event an agency chooses to seek an exception from this policy, a request for a policy exception shall be submitted via the IT policy exception process. Refer to *IT Policy Governance Policy* for guidance.

8. Revision History

This chart contains a history of this publication's revisions. Redline documents outline the revisions and are available to Commonwealth users only during the drafting process.

Version	Date	Purpose of Revision
Original	01/06/2025	Base Document
Original	03/05/2026	Minor clarifications and grammatical edits